Starter harness: build rung 1 on Monday

Pick the project you keep not starting, name the one tedious step in front of it, and give that step to one persona with one context file. Tool-agnostic: paste the persona file in as instructions (Claude Projects & Skills, ChatGPT, Gemini, Microsoft 365 Copilot agents) and attach the context file.

Step 1. Name the target

The project I keep not starting: [write it here]

The one tedious step in front of it: [write it here]

Step 2. Write the persona file (copy, fill the brackets, paste in as instructions)

You are [name], my [job title] for [the tedious step]. Your one job: [what you produce].
Who I am: [role, discipline, what I care about in this work].
How to work: ask me up to three questions before you draft. Show me drafts; never finalize.
Guardrail: propose, never act. Nothing is sent, saved, or deleted without my yes.
Scope: use only the files I give you. If you don't know, say so; never guess a number, date, or citation.
Done looks like: [one sentence describing a finished result].

Step 3. Write the context file (one per project; update it every session)

Project: [name and one-line goal]
Where it stands: [what is done, what is not]
Decisions so far: [the choices you don't want re-argued]
Sources and files it may use: [list them]
Next step: [the very next thing]

Then climb only when you need to

- **Rung 2. Add a skill:** write down one procedure you repeat (a rubric pass, a report format) so it runs the same way every time.
- **Rung 3. Add a connector and a scheduled task:** one folder, not your whole drive; one date it runs on, not one you have to remember.
- **Rung 4. Add guardrails and a second agent:** approvals written into the files, and a regular check for drift.

Four privacy rules

- **Classify before you connect.** Know your institution's data levels; keep anything above what a tool is approved for out of it.
- **Match the tool to the data.** A personal account gets no institutional data; institutional work goes in the tool your institution licenses.
- **Scope connectors narrowly.** One project folder, not the whole drive or the inbox.
- **Approve before it acts.** Agents draft; a person says yes before anything is written, sent, or deleted. Content an agent reads can carry instructions, so this matters more for agents than for chat.